



Prologue

“How to Study Cities”

Richard T. LeGates



Studying cities is a vast and never-ending enterprise. There is too much material for any one individual to master and always more to learn. Fortunately many fine scholars, past and present, have focused their attention on cities. We now know a great deal about how cities evolved, their social structures, urban culture, their internal spatial organization and relationships to other cities in systems or networks of cities, what economic functions they perform, how they are governed, how they are planned, how to design them, urban placemaking, the impact of globalization and information technology on cities and the probable future of cities and city regions. In addition to descriptive analyses about what cities *are* like there is a great deal of good normative writing expressing authors' opinions of what they *should* be like. We pay special attention to both the role of utopian thought about cities and predictions and normative theory about what city planners and policy makers might do to make cities better. One premise of *The City Reader* is that much of the classic writing about cities over the past hundred years remains remarkably relevant today. Another is that we are living now in a period of enormous change in the world city network that demands attention to entirely new patterns in urban society, culture, economics, governance, and policy.

DISCIPLINARY AND INTERDISCIPLINARY TEACHING ABOUT CITIES

While academic teaching about cities occurs in courses as different as English literature and civil engineering, most urban scholarship can be grouped under the heading of “urban studies,” as an urban specialization within one of the social science disciplines such as “urban geography,” “urban sociology,” “urban politics,” “urban economics,” or “urban anthropology,” or in applied professional courses in urban planning, architecture, and landscape architecture. A description of these fields and disciplines and how they fit into universities is helpful to students encountering this material for the first time. Almost all modern universities organize teaching and research into academic units called schools or colleges such as a college of social science or a school of architecture and urban planning. Schools and colleges in turn are generally organized into academic departments around a single discipline such as a department of geography. Many universities also offer interdisciplinary programs related to cities, such as an urban studies program that requires students to take courses in a variety of different academic disciplines and fields. Professors educated in different academic disciplines are located within the departments and programs: historians in the history department, economists in the economic department, and sociologists in the sociology department. City and regional planning and urban studies departments are generally interdisciplinary and have faculty trained in a variety of academic disciplines and professional fields. The ten-person faculty of a mid-sized US city and regional planning department, for example, might have a core faculty of ten professors: three who

received PhDs in city and regional planning, two with degrees in architecture or urban design, one with a law degree, and one each with a PhD in economics, geography, statistics, and political science.

Regardless of whether or not they have interdisciplinary major or minors, most universities encourage research and teaching that crosses disciplinary boundaries. For example, a university may encourage a historian to teach a course that serves students in an urban studies department or the urban studies department may include the economics department's urban economics course as a required or elective course for the urban studies major.

While professors from many different academic disciplines as well as interdisciplinary scholars study cities, most of the academic literature about cities—and most of the readings in *The City Reader* and the Routledge Urban Reader Series—has been written by social scientists: faculty trained to systematically study different aspects of human society from the perspective of an established social science discipline. Some writing in *The City Reader*, and many of the selections in *The Urban and Regional Planning Reader* and the *Urban Design Reader* in the Routledge Urban Reader Series were written by scholars in applied fields related to urban planning and design—city and regional planning, architecture, urban design, and landscape architecture.

Most universities have a school or college of social science. Schools of social science contain social science departments where professors trained in the social science disciplines of geography, sociology, economics, political science, and anthropology teach. History departments are sometimes located within schools of social science, sometimes within schools of humanities. Within these social science departments, professors interested in cities teach urban courses from the point of view of their disciplines: courses on urban geography, urban sociology, urban politics, etc. Professors in these discipline-based courses may include material written by scholars from other academic disciplines in their courses. For example a geography professor may use content and methods developed by economists and sociologists in her urban geography course.

Departments of city and regional planning (often called town and country planning in the UK) are often located within professional colleges that group architecture, planning, landscape architecture, and sometimes other departments related to the built environment.

Distinctions may be drawn between substantive content, methods, and theory in the different academic disciplines and professional fields related to the study of cities. While social science has an established body of methods that academics from all social science disciplines use, each discipline has its own preference and variations. Urban economists tend to use quantitative methods such as statistical analysis of data to show the relationship between poverty and crime, and urban sociologists tend to use qualitative methods such as direct field observation of majority-minority communities. But some urban economists use qualitative methods and some urban sociologists are very quantitative. Social scientists usually draw more heavily on work by members of their own discipline than other disciplines. But most also use material from other disciplines and professional fields. Most of the academic literature about urban politics is by political scientists based on theory and methods political scientists use. But law professor Myron Orfield (p. 338) mapped metropolitan areas using Geographical Information Systems (GIS) software to develop his theory of metropolitics, which has become influential among political scientists. Sociologist Saskia Sassen's writings on the global system of cities (p. 650) are widely read by planners, economists, and political scientists.

Disciplines have the advantage that they are based on more or less agreed-upon methods for acquiring knowledge and a more or less agreed-upon body of knowledge shared by the discipline. All history professors, for example, in order to get their history PhD must study the methods of historical research that historians use. All history professors will have taken enough different history courses that they have a good overall knowledge of history in addition to their specialties in one or more specific time periods, issue areas, or methods of historical inquiry.

A disadvantage of disciplines is that they encourage rigid thinking within the four corners of the discipline itself. There is a danger that professors who are rigorously trained in economics, for example, will see only economic factors as important when they study or teach about an issue such as urban sprawl. Because they have been trained in the importance of economics they may neglect political, social, and spatial aspects

of sprawl. Of course understanding urban sprawl as an economic problem related to differential land costs, changing job locations, infrastructure finance, the cost of gas, and other important economic factors is important. But understanding the sociology of suburbanites, the relationship of single-family suburban home design to sprawl, spatial aspects of ethnic clustering in suburbs, and a host of other issues that bear only indirectly on economics will further enrich understanding of suburbs. In sum, the strength of interdisciplinary approaches is that, done properly, an interdisciplinary approach provides for a richer, more holistic, more varied understanding of multiple dimensions of the phenomena being studied than a study from a single disciplinary perspective.

The weakness of interdisciplinary approaches is that they may become so loose and standardless that they lack intellectual rigor. Well-trained and specialized disciplinary scholars are often justifiably critical of colleagues who do wide but shallow interdisciplinary teaching, research, and writing.

THEORY AND PRACTICE

Academic writing about cities is guided by theory—logically coherent bodies of principles advanced to explain phenomena. Theory in the social sciences is intended to provide a framework for understanding. Manuel Castells's theory about the "space of flows" (p. 229), for example, provides rich insights that help explain how digital information flows affect the global system of cities.

Some professors value only basic research and theory-building and look down on applied research and writing intended to produce solutions to actual urban problems. They see applied research as derivative and inferior—a kind of vocational education that is not worthy of true scholars. This is silly. Cities lend themselves well to applied research.

Good scholarship directed at problem-solving can be just as theoretically subtle and methodologically sophisticated as pure academic research. William H. Whyte's thoughtful prescriptions for park and plaza design based on his observations of New York City parks and plazas (p. 587), James Q. Wilson and George L. Kelling's "broken windows" theory of community policing based on their observations of police work in Newark, New Jersey (p. 259), and John Forester's theories about mediating urban planning conflicts (p. 467) based on dozens of interviews with practicing planners are as intellectually rigorous as any of the more academic selections in *The City Reader*.

Peter Hall (p. 431) and others deplore the lack of connection between urban theory and urban practice. We agree. Theory and practice should be linked in studying cities. Theory can inform practice and practice can inform theory. John Forester's approach is a good example of how to do this. Forester (p. 467) developed his theories about how urban planners manage conflict by talking to practitioners. The theory he developed is in turn helpful to practitioners.

METHODS FOR STUDYING CITIES

Scholars who study cities use both quantitative and qualitative research methods. Both approaches can contribute to understanding cities. The best urban research designs often combine both quantitative and qualitative research and triangulate on problems using multiple methods.

Quantitative methods involve analyzing data using statistical methods. Today virtually all quantitative analysis is done with computer software. A professor of urban politics doing statistical analysis of city voting data to see if recent immigrants feel differently about immigration than longer-term non-immigrant residents would be doing quantitative urban research. At the undergraduate level, applied statistics is a regular part of most urban studies and urban planning curricula and sometimes required in other social science disciplines. Students learn to use computerized statistical packages such as the Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS) to do quantitative analysis. At the graduate level, virtually all students take required courses in quantitative methods.

Time is an important dimension in much urban research. Researchers may choose to look at an issue at one specific point in time. Imagine scientists studying a hundred-foot-long cylindrical sample of polar ice that had built up over a thousand years to determine the amount of carbon from the atmosphere that settled on the ice at different times in the past in order to understand global climate change. Cutting a small slice of the cylinder where carbon froze into the cylinder in the year 1682 and analyzing it for carbon content would be an example of what is called cross-sectional research. Friedrich Engels's study of the deplorable living and working conditions of factory workers in Manchester, England, in 1844 (p. 53) is another good example of cross-sectional urban research. The conditions Engels described in 1844 were different from what they were in earlier years and they would change in the future. But his snapshot of what conditions were like in Manchester during that one year provides a devastating cross-sectional picture of what Manchester was like in 1844.

A research design that chooses to look at how conditions change over time is called a longitudinal research design. Kingsley Davis's study of the urbanization of the human population from the early Middle Ages through the latter part of the twentieth century (p. 19) is an example of longitudinal research. By looking at population data for European cities over a thousand-year period, Davis was able to describe changes that would not have been possible from a cross-sectional study. The line chart and table in Tingwei Zhang's description the trajectory of China's urbanization (p. 687) is another good example of cross-sectional analysis.

Geographical space is an important aspect in much urban research. Most statistical analysis of urban phenomena is aspatial (does not include geographical space as a variable). But because many urban phenomena have a spatial dimension, Geographical Information Systems (GIS) software that permits users to map and analyze data is very important in studying cities and preparing city and regional plans. GIS is taught in geography, urban planning, and other departments. Myron Orfield's use of GIS to map attributes of cities in metropolitan regions to identify common needs and political interests (p. 338) is an excellent example of urban spatial analysis.

Qualitative research usually does not involve numbers or statistical analysis. William H. Whyte's use of observation (including time lapse photography) to find out how people use urban parks and plazas (p. 587) is a good example of effective use of one qualitative urban research method. Urban sociologist Elijah Anderson conducted exhaustive qualitative field research in black ghetto areas of Chicago and New York (p. 131). Anderson's descriptions of what residents told him paints a complex and subtle portrait that would be impossible to capture with quantitative methods. Urban designer Kevin Lynch and his students' interviews with Boston residents to understand how they perceived the city image (p. 576) is another excellent example of effective qualitative research that Lynch combined with spatial analysis of residents' mental maps, survey research, and other methods to derive his theory of how people perceive the image of the city.

There is never only one "right" way to do urban research. Multiple methods help researchers triangulate on a problem. Thus, a researcher might choose to do both cross-sectional and longitudinal, qualitative and quantitative research on urban sprawl. The quantitative research might involve both aspatial analysis using a computerized statistical package and mapping and spatial statistical analysis using GIS. Within this broad research design the researcher could choose a variety of methods depending on his or her skills, the time available, and costs. Literature searches, observation, interviewing, depth interviews, web-based research, phone or mail surveys, focus groups, analysis of big data from a secondary source, case studies, and many other methods are widely used in urban research.

While this is not a book about urban research methods, some of the selection introductions comment on the research methods used in the selection. For all the other selections it is always important to pay attention to the research methods used as well as the substance.

ORGANIZATIONS AND JOURNALS DEVOTED TO THE STUDY OF CITIES

A number of academic associations organize conferences, set standards, publish academic journals, and work to advance scholarship related to understanding cities.

In North America the academic association most directly concerned with urban studies is the Urban Affairs Association (UAA). The European counterpart organization is the European Urban Research Association (EURA). Both UAA and EURA include faculty and students from a variety of social sciences, urban planning, and other backgrounds among their members. In addition to organizing annual conference both UAA and EURA publish leading scholarly journals. The UAA publishes *The Journal of Urban Affairs* and EURA publishes *Urban Research & Practice*.

In North America, the organization of urban planning schools is the Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning (ACSP); in Europe, the Association of European Schools of Planning (AESOP). Members of ACSP who are interested in international planning education have formed the Global Planning Educators Interest Group (GPEIG), which maintains a lively and informative website with a worldwide urban planning focus.

In addition to their annual meetings in North America and Europe, every five years ACSP and AESOP hold a joint congress alternating between a site in North America and a site in Europe. There are organizations of planning schools for Asia, Latin America, Australia and New Zealand, Canada, Brazil and other Portuguese-speaking countries, and France and other francophone countries.

The Global Planning Educators Association Network (GPEAN) maintains a website with links to all of the above associations of planning schools. Each of the member associations' sites has links to their members' sites. Every five years GPEAN holds an international conference for planning educators somewhere in the world.

World congresses of planning schools are held every five years. The first world congress of planning schools occurred in Shanghai in 2001; the second in Mexico City in 2006; the third in Perth, Australia in 2011. A fourth GPEAN world congress will take place in 2016.

Disciplinary academic organizations—such as the American Sociological Association (ASA), American Political Science Association (APSA), American Economic Association (AEA), and the Association of American Geographers (AAG)—have specialized member groups dealing with urban concerns. Urban “tracks” at these conferences bring urbanists with similar interests together to present and discuss scholarly papers and otherwise share information.

The main professional association of practicing city planners in the United States is the American Planning Association (APA). In the United Kingdom an equivalent organization is the Royal Town Planning Institute (RTPI). Practicing planners in these organizations meet to discuss their professional interests at national and subnational meetings.

Journals such as *Urban Studies* (published by Sage Publications), *The Journal of Urban Affairs* (published by UAA), *Urban Studies*, and *The International Journal of Urban and Regional Research* specialize in publishing scholarly articles related to cities. *The Journal of Planning Education and Research* (published by ACSP) is North America's leading academic urban planning journal. *The American Planning Association Journal* (published by APA) is an excellent scholarly journal with a somewhat more applied focus. *The Town Planning Review* (published by RTPI) is the leading UK scholarly urban planning journal. *Urban Planning Forum* (published in Chinese by Tongji University) and *City Planning Review* (published in English) are China's leading urban planning journals.